Even as I was writing this book, the Indian government came up with a proposal to re-introduce the cheetah into the country from Africa. Furious debates rage on whether or not the African and Asian cheetahs belong to the same species. There are even more furious debates about mining. The primordial forests of Gondwana are now rich coal fields in Jharkhand. India's economic expansion is hungry for energy and covets the coal that lies below the beautiful, rolling hills of the state. No matter which side one takes in the debate, my tour of the coal mines of Hazaribagh suggested that the extraction of resources needs to be done in a way that significantly reduces the social and environmental costs of this activity. These natural resources are not renewable and we must have good reason for exploiting them today rather than leaving them for future generations.

We live in a time of massive change—mass urbanization, climate change, globalization, and a shifting global order. India has seen all this before, but the human inability to learn from the past is sometimes astounding. I write these lines in Varanasi as I watch the evening 'aarati' on the ancient ghats along the Ganga. The priests chant the glories of the great river and seek her blessings, but the river is clearly dying from the assaults of human interference and thoughtless civil engineering. Perhaps the Harappans chanted hymns extolling the glories of the Saraswati as they impotently watched the river dry up. Perhaps they desperately invoked Indra to break the dams and let the waters flow again.

As we have seen, despite all this change, Indians have retained an intuitive memory of their civilization. It continues to influence Indian attitudes in surprising ways. A lot can be discerned about a people from the way they remember their darkest hour. When New York observes an anniversary of the 9/11 attacks, there is a sombre service and speeches by leading political figures. Contrast that with how Mumbai commemorated the terrorist attacks of 26 November 2008. A day after the fourth anniversary, a flash mob of 200 young boys and girls suddenly appeared in the middle of Chhatrapati Shivaji Terminal, a busy train station that had witnessed one of the massacres on that night of horror. The flash mob then proceeded to dance for five minutes to a popular Bollywood number *Rang*